How to do system thinking

If system thinking must be done in the public policy process, how should it be organized?

The first threat is that of the designers within government having the wrong design. To avoid this problem, a strong policy pipeline is required, with evidence, debate and the development of consensus in the expert community. If a design is made by any small group of people, without ample debate over elongated periods of time across a broad expert community, there is a greater risk of being wrong.

As an example, in the international engineering community, many important technical standards have been developed by the ‘Internet Engineering Task Force’ (IETF). This is an open process through which rival firms, academics and enthusiasts are able to debate and develop standards. Such a process has a better chance of avoiding errors and of achieving democratic legitimacy.

The second problem to address is the views of affected persons. A design that appears attractive to its creators might impose tremendous difficulties upon the economy. Broad-based consultation is required, with a large number of affected persons, in order to hear diverse views. Social systems are complex, and a design that appears clean to an engineer might induce unpleasant unintentional consequences for some individuals in society.

As with all government intervention, it is important to clearly state the problem that is sought to be solved, define what constitutes success, and set up a measurement system to watch how the economy is responding to the initiative. It is important to be humble, to recognize when things have not gone as planned, and be ready to change course.

A thumb rule that we would advocate runs as follows: Each policy thinker should permit herself a budget constraint of supporting no more than one policy proposal, that involves system thinking, in her life.